

1948–1959

FEMININE FORM

Tailoring for women was one of the strongest trends in 1950s fashion. Smart two-piece suits with architectural shapes and sculpted lines reflected the sophistication and modern aspirations of the times. From the mid-1930s tailoring had become an important part of the female wardrobe, partly inspired by military wear and partly dictated by a need for practical garb for women who worked outside the home. In the 1950s designers exploited tailor's techniques to help create an idealized feminine form. Innovators such as US-based Charles James and Spanish Cristóbal Balenciaga injected fresh ideas into suiting and framing the body. Jackets were typically rounded at the shoulder, rather than square and padded, and were tightly fitted through the bodice to shape a small waist before flaring out to accentuate the hips. Skirts hit mid-calf and were either pencil slim or very full.

HATS



Bird-topped tricorne
by Maud et
Nano, 1951



Cartwheel hat
with silk edging



Beret with
quill-like feather



Toreador style
with haispot veil

In the 1950s the mark of a well-dressed woman was her hat. For day and evening, small hats were in vogue, especially pillbox, cloche, or beret styles, although cartwheel shapes were also worn. The popularity of the cocktail hour led to fanciful creations that added drama to an outfit. These often sat towards the back of the head to prevent flattening the carefully coiffed hair. Hats were almost always adorned with veils, feathers, birds, fruit, flowers, or other whimsy.

Trim waistline
echoes "New Look"

Slanted
pockets
at hip add
volume

1948



Full A-line
skirt shape

Neat pleats This grey worsted suit by British designer Hardy Amies retains the influence of Dior's 1947 New Look silhouette. Amies adapts the full-skirted shape into a sharp tailored suit with the use of a panel of narrow pleats.

Black buttons
match braid
detail

Understated
tailoring

1952



Toffee-
coloured
wool

Precision tailoring This suit by British designer Charles Creed is simple but exact in cut and construction. Decoration is kept restrained with inset bands of black braid and small loops, repeated at the back of the skirt.

Short, wide
sleeves for
pairing with
long gloves

Wide,
rounded
collar

Oversized
buttons add
drama

Flared
jacket hem
slims the
hipline

1953



Lightweight wool suit US designer Norman Norell partnered with Anthony Traina to set up the Norell-Traina label. Their designs were elegant yet relaxed, like this 1954 ensemble of a slim, straight skirt and half-sleeve jacket.